

Μέλαμπος ὁ Μάντις

Melampus the Diviner on Pulses and the Body

eul_aid: nuw

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Κοινή τεχνική [Technical Koine](#)
Domain: Ἐπιστήμη [Science](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Melampus the Diviner was a Greek author who lived and wrote during the Roman Imperial period, likely in the 1st or 2nd century CE. His exact dates, birthplace, and personal history are not recorded. He wrote under the name Melampus, which was traditionally associated with a mythical Greek seer, a common practice to lend authority to technical writings of the time.

He is known for writing systematic handbooks on divination, a field considered a technical science in the ancient world. His only definitively surviving work is a treatise titled *On Divination by Bodily Signs*, also referred to as *On Palmistry*. This text methodically explains how to foretell the future by interpreting physical characteristics, particularly the lines on a person's hands and other bodily marks.

According to modern scholars, his work is a valuable example of how popular divinatory practices, like palm-reading, were formalized into written technical literature. It provides important insight into the blend of empirical observation and traditional belief in the Greco-Roman world. The treatise illustrates the broader cultural interest in compiling and systematizing knowledge during the Roman era.

Works (4)

- Περὶ παλμῶν μαντική πρὸς Πτολεμαῖον βασιλέα · [On Divination by Pulses to King Ptolemy](#) · 108 passages
- Περὶ παλμῶν ἀρχομένου ἀπὸ κεφαλῆς ἕως ποδῶν · [On Pulses](#) · 82 passages
- Περὶ ἐλαιῶν τοῦ σώματος πρὸς Πτολεμαῖον βασιλέα · [On the Oils of the Body to King Ptolemy](#) · 8 passages
- Περὶ παλμῶν τί σημαίνουν ἐν ἐκάστῳ μέρει · [On What Pulses Indicate in Each Part](#) · 77 passages